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Vishal Kaliraman missed his first international competition of 2026 with an injury. But the 25-year-old doesn't sound like someone who regrets it. The men's 65kg wrestler was supposed to begin his season at the Zagreb Open (UWW Ranking Series) in the first week of February. Instead, he has spent the last few weeks at New Delhi's Chhatrasal Akhara, recovering from



an ankle twist picked up during the Pro Wrestling League (PWL).

Wrestling for UP Dominators, Kaliraman picked up the injury during his bout against Mongolia's Tulga Tumur Ochir. Ochir was representing Haryana Thunders.

Kaliraman went in as the underdog, but fought back from 0-6 down to win 6-6 on criteria against Ochir, the reigning Asian Games champion and a two-time Worlds medallist.

"Although I got injured during the bout, I didn't even realise it. I'd wrestled against this same wrestler at the Asian Championships last year and had lost easily (0-8). But this time I was able to fight back and beat him. Although I missed a tournament because of it, I think the confidence I gained from that victory is worth it. I don't regret taking part in the League at all," Kaliraman says.

It's a sentiment echoed by many wrestlers who competed in the 2026 edition of PWL. For them, the league offered something Indian wrestling rarely provides: a professional stage, elite opposition, and daily access to international medal winners.

The team-based league was first conducted in 2015. Its team format, colourful costumes, ring girls, smoke machines, theme music and TV production, paired with high-quality

Sizing up opponents: Yui Susaki (right) during her stint in India, where she faced local talent and took stock of the next generation of challengers.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

elite wrestlers from around the world, were a world apart from the rustic, mud-and-mat image Indian wrestling is often associated with. However, the league folded after four seasons, amid talk of management disputes and poor returns to investors.

So, when the league was announced again in late 2025, under a new management, wrestlers allowed themselves cautious optimism.

"A lot of us had followed the league when it was last conducted. At that time, I was a very young wrestler. I had always hoped to get to wrestle in the league. I really wanted my parents to see me on TV. As a wrestler, most of our matches are only shown on internet streaming. It's different when you are on TV," says 18-year-old Neha Sangwan, who competed for Haryana Thunders.

But the excitement came with nerves.

"We were looking forward to it, but at the same time, we were